

MARCO LO FASO

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EDUCATION

University of Southern California Los Angeles, CA Ph.D. in Economics	Aug 2021 - May 2027 (expected)
Harvard University Cambridge, MA Visiting Ph.D. Student, Department of Economics	Aug 2025 - July 2026
Bocconi University Milan, ITA M.Sc. in Public Policy and Political Economy	Sept 2016 - March 2019
Bocconi University Milan, ITA B.Sc. in Economics	Sept 2013 - Sept 2016

RESEARCH FIELDS

Applied Microeconomics, Spatial Economics, Political Economy

RESEARCH

“The Geography of Protests”

- *Abstract* This project explores how urban geography influences political mobilization within cities. While recent research has emphasized informational frictions as a barrier to protest participation, I argue that the spatial structure of cities also plays a critical role. Using data from the George Floyd protests, I identify protest venues across U.S. cities by combining media reports with mobile phone location data. I then construct granular measures of urban connectivity—such as travel time and network centrality—using street network data from OpenStreetMap. These measures allow me to estimate spatial frictions in foot traffic flows between neighborhoods and protest venues. Preliminary results suggest that distance deters foot traffic activity, and this deterrent effect strengthens during protest weeks. Building on these findings, I will test whether fragmented protests—those dispersed across multiple venues—generate greater political backlash, especially in swing neighborhoods. I will also explore whether variation in protest exposure affects voter behavior, politician messaging, and policy outcomes such as policing budgets. The project contributes to both urban economics and political economy by integrating spatial frictions into models of collective action. It also informs urban planning by highlighting how network structure influences democratic engagement

“The Labor Market Returns to Religious Networks: Evidence from Uganda” (with Aruj Shukla)

“Selfish Parents: Children Migration, Schooling Investment and Political Preferences”

EXPERIENCE

University of Southern California <i>Research Assistant for professor Augustin Bergeron</i>	May 2023 - Dec 2023
Pompeu Fabra University Barcelona, ESP <i>Research Assistant for professor Ruben Durante</i>	Sept 2020 - Aug 2021
Bocconi University Milan, ITA <i>Research Assistant for professor Vincenzo Galasso</i>	Sept 2019 - Aug 2020
European Central Bank Frankfurt, GER <i>Research Intern</i>	Jan 2019 - Aug 2019
European Commission Brussels, BEL <i>Economic Analyst</i>	Aug 2017 - Apr 2018

ACADEMIC WORK, EXPERIENCE AND SERVICE

Teaching Assistant, University of Southern California ECON 318 – Introduction to Econometrics – Italo Lopez Garcia, Jeff Weaver (undergraduate) ECON 436 – Political Economy and Economic Development – Augustin Bergeron (undergraduate)	Sept 2022 - May 2024
Teaching Assistant, Pompeu Fabra University Public Economics – Ruben Durante (undergraduate)	Sept 2020 - Aug 2021

Teaching Assistant, INSEAD <i>Public Policy – Ruben Durante (MBA)</i>	Sept 2020 - Aug 2021
Teaching Assistant, Bocconi University <i>Welfare and Politics – Vincenzo Galasso (master)</i> <i>Economics of European Integration – Carlo Altomonte (master)</i> <i>Political Economics – Vincenzo Galasso (undergraduate)</i> <i>European Economic Policy – Carlo Altomonte (undergraduate)</i>	Sept 2019 - Aug 2020
ACES Summer School in Political Economy, UC Berkeley	Aug 2023
Summer School in Economics of Migration, Global Migration Center UC Davis	Sept 2024
Co-organizer – Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics, USC	Oct 2023

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Lusk Research Center for Real Estate (for “The Geography of Protests”): \$15,000.00
 Dan James Fellowship (for “The Geography of Protests”): \$40,000.00
 Weiss Fund Research Grant (for “The Labor Market Returns to Religious Networks”): \$5,000.00
 USC Summer Research Award (x3): \$4,000.00

MISCELLANEOUS

Programming Skills: Python, R, Stata, Matlab
Languages: Italian, English
Other: Citizenship: Italian, Visa Holder: F1 (USA)

REFERENCES

Thomas Chaney (Chair)
 John Elliott Chair in Economics and Professor of Economics
 Department of Economics
 University of Southern California
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 Assistant Professor of Economics
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